

BUYERS' GUIDE

ESTYLE

Keep Connected With These 3G/4G DONGLES



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The wireless age is here! In a connected world like ours, everyone wants Internet access on-the-go. Even high-end laptops these day exclude the Ethernet port.

All Internet dongles promise to give you fast speeds, but how do you choose which one is meant for you? What are the features that you must look for while selecting a dongle? This guide will help you decide.

Key features of dongles

There are a bunch of different specifications that you need to understand and keep in mind when shopping for a dongle. Some might be faster than the others but can maintain a much lower number of connections—this could work against you if you have ten devices trying to connect to it. To ensure that you make the right choice, keep the following specifications in mind.

Speed. Of all the features of a Wi-Fi dongle, this is the most important. However,

there is a lot of ambiguity when it comes to the actual speed that a dongle offers. This is due to the fact that the speed promised by the manufacturer can only be delivered if the telecom service provider has the required connectivity in that area.

Some dongles are advertised to have a download speed of up to 21.1Mbps, but the actual speed is nowhere near that because the network strength in that area cannot support it. Before buying a specific dongle, it may be good idea to request a demo at the store itself—you can check the actual Internet speed that it offers with Ookla Speedtest service. It is available on www.speedtest.net

Number of devices it can support. This refers to the number of devices that can be connected to the Internet using a single dongle. Some dongles do not allow you to create a Wi-Fi hotspot, and can provide Internet connectivity to only one system. However, there are others that allow you to create a Wi-Fi hotspot.

Generally, about five devices can use a hotspot that has been set up using one dongle. Some dongles can support up to ten devices at a time. Of course, one has to keep in mind that the speed comes down considerably as more and more devices are connected to a single network.

Range. This refers to the distance at which the signal of the dongle can be clearly received. For offices, dongles with wider ranges are preferred. If you plan to use the dongle in a single room only, then you do not have to worry too much about the range of the signal.

Expandable memory. Some dongles in the market come with a microSD card slot, so the memory can be expanded. This can be very convenient if you have to transfer data from one system to another—it eliminates the need to buy an additional drive for data storage. Generally, microSD

SOME 3G/4G DONGLES AVAILABLE IN THE MARKET

Dongle	Connectivity	HSDPA (Mbps)	HSUPA (Mbps)	Hotspot facility	Expandable memory	Locked/unlocked	Price
Huawei Power-Fi E8231	3G	21.6	5.76	Yes	Not available	Unlocked	₹ 1749 (amazon.in)
ZTE MF190	3G	7.2	5.76	No	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 639 (flipkart.in)
D-Link DWP-157	3G	21	5.76	No	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 1049 (amazon.in)
iBall Airway 21.0MP-58	2G/3G	21	5.76	Yes	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 1089 (amazon.in)
Micromax MMX444L	4G	68	17.8	Yes	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 2499 (snapdeal.com)
D-Link DWR-710 Lepetit	3G	21	11.4	Yes	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 1594 (amazon.in)
Huawei Power-Fi E8221	3G	14.4	5.76	Yes	Not available	Unlocked	₹ 1660 (amazon.in)
Huawei E3531 USB Surfstick	3G	21.6	5.76	Yes	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 1246 (amazon.in)
ZTE MF197	3G	14.4	5.76	No	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 799 (amazon.in)
Intex 21.6 SWM Data Card	3G	21.6	11	Yes	Upto 32GB	Unlocked	₹ 978 (amazon.in)

All prices listed are the lowest prices mentioned on the websites at the time of writing the article.